



Dropping supplies

Supplies landed by helicopter are loaded onto a truck for distribution. Empty supply boxes were often filled with sand and used as defense against mortars.

Air strikes

The air war over South Vietnam also involved the tactical support of American ground troops, who could call for fixed-wing air strikes from Air Force or Navy bombers and covering fire from helicopter gunships. The range and power of such air strikes was much greater than that of conventional artillery and formed an important component of search-and-destroy strategy. Spooky, the modified Douglas AC-47, for example, could direct a curtain of machine gun fire onto a target for an hour or more. Weapons, houses, people—everything under fire from Spooky was turned to mulch.

Forward air controllers tried to exercise discretion over calling in air strikes when civilians were present. However, like the ground war strategy of search-and-destroy, the air war over South Vietnam often involved indiscriminate violence. American use of “free fire zones”—areas targeted by bombing and artillery in which all Vietnamese people who had not evacuated were assumed to be enemy combatants—resulted in unknown civilian casualties and contributed to South Vietnam’s refugee crisis. Antipersonnel chemical weapons, such as napalm and white phosphorus, which caused untreatable wounds, resulted in further suffering.